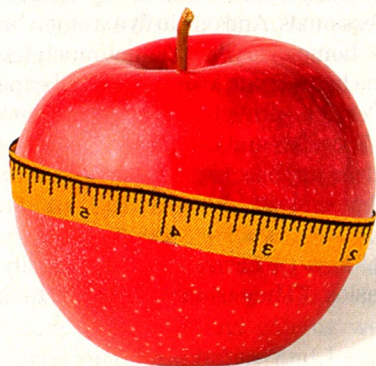


3 out of **4** city women have a waistline over 32 inches, the danger score in obesity.

A 5.5 ft woman faces societal fat bias at **73** kg. A 5.9 ft man does so at **107** kg.

Weighty women twice as likely to be depressed and consume **20%** more calories.



75 per cent Indian women in the cities are apple-shaped, while **58** per cent men are so.

Source: AIIMS, NFHS, IJO, IDEA 2004-2008

■ By Damayanti Datta

Tall, strapping and statuesque, Shivalli M. Chouhan, 34, doesn't look fat, but she insists she is. "It's not my self-image. It's what others tell me," smiles the civil servant with the Indian Defence Accounts Service. It's what her teacher had said long back when she was chosen for a television dance show in school. It's what some of her batchmates had whispered when she won those beauty contests in college and university. Resentful of the constant pressure of other people's unending desire for her to be thin she decided to excel

in everything else but looks. She topped her university, did her PhD in economics, passed the gruelling civil service exams and has just finished her stint as the first woman civil servant on the country's peacekeeping forces abroad. A happy wife and a mother, she says, "I am determined not to be bogged down."

The talking point so long has been the "girth of the nation". There's a turn in the tide and a new focus on women now. Urban Indian women are piling on the pounds and doing so faster than men. Three out of four women have waistlines measuring well over 80 cm or 32 inches (the danger score in obesity) while one out of four are either overweight or obese, reports the latest National Family Health Survey III (NFHS). In 2004, the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) reported over 50 per cent women between age 35 and 59 in urban India, compared to 40 per cent men, to be overweight. In 2006, 75 per cent urban women were found to be apple-shaped, compared to 58 per cent men, by the 60-country International Day of Evaluation of Abdominal Obesity (IDEA) study. Women face markedly different risks, too. World Health Organisation (WHO) data suggests that overweight women face six times more disease burden than men—from diabetes to heart attacks, 10 types of cancer to dementia, asthma to Alzheimer's, psoriasis to polycystic ovary syndrome, miscarriage to infertility.

But why does obesity hit women harder? Conventional wisdom blames women for their condition. "On the surface, they are eating too much high-calorie food, not burning it off with enough activity, splurging on lifestyle, spurning household chores," says cardiologist, Dr Naresh Trehan. Over 77 per cent women with full-time domestic help were found to put on weight faster and more than those with part-timers (47 per cent) or none (27 per cent), by Praween Agrawal of Indian Institute of Population Sciences, Mumbai in 2004. "But by that logic, men should bloat up more," says Trehan. "Most Indian men don't do any housework and spend their workdays behind a desk. Also career women, juggling work and home, can't exactly be called sitting ducks." Yet, in a study involving 3,000 executives, Trehan's team had found obesity in 43 per cent women, compared to 24 per cent men.

The answer lies elsewhere. Unlike men, obesity is not just a consequence of lifestyle excesses brought on by new affluence in women, hold experts. And "psychology of obesity" is the jargon doing the rounds. For the first time, new compulsions, demands, aspirations and disappointments in the modern woman's life are being considered as